Daily News 29 / 05 / 2024

Brussels, 29 May 2024

Commission decides to close the Article 7(1) TEU procedure for Poland

Today, the European Commission **has decided to close the Article 7(1) TEU procedure for Poland** by withdrawing its reasoned proposal that had triggered this procedure in 2017. On 6 May 2024, the Commission finalised its analysis on the rule of law situation in Poland in the context of the Article 7(1) TEU procedure. **The Commission considers that there is no longer a clear risk of a serious breach of the rule of law in Poland** within the meaning of that provision. Poland has launched a series of legislative and non-legislative measures to address the concerns on independence of the justice system, it has recognised the primacy of EU law and is committed to implementing all the judgments of the Court of Justice of the European Union and the European Court of Human Rights related to rule of law including judicial independence.

During the General Affairs Council on 21 May 2024, the Vice-President for Values and Transparency, Věra **Jourová**, had a positive discussion with ministers on the situation in Poland under the Article 7 procedure, as well as on the latest Commission assessment and the intention to withdraw the reasoned proposal. Member States recognised the efforts already made by the Polish Government to address the existing concerns. Following this discussion, **the Commission has today decided to close the Article 7 procedure,** and has informed the Council and the European Parliament that it is withdrawing its reasoned proposal of 2017.

Vice-President **Jourová** said: *"Today marks an important day for the rule of law in Poland and in the European Union. After more than six years, following the positive steps taken by the Polish authorities as well as the strong support expressed by Member States in that respect, we have now closed the Article 7 procedure for Poland. We will continue engaging with the Polish authorities to support them in their endeavour to promote the rule of law."*

The Commission will continue to monitor the measures under the Action Plan, as well as other steps to promote the rule of law in Poland, in particular under the Rule of Law Report process.

(For more information: Anitta Hipper - Tel.: +32 2 298 56 91; Jördis Ferroli – Tel.: +32 2 299 27 29)

Les Européens continuent de se sentir directement concernés par les questions et les politiques environnementales

Selon une nouvelle enquête Eurobaromètre sur les « Attitudes des Européens à l'égard de l'environnement», publiée aujourd'hui, les Européens continuent d'exprimer un **niveau de préoccupation élevé à l'égard de l'environnement**, qu'ils considèrent comme une question les touchant personnellement.

Plus de trois quarts des Européens déclarent que les **questions environnementales ont un effet direct sur leur vie quotidienne et sur leur santé**. Et plus de quatre personnes interrogées sur cinq reconnaissent que la **législation environnementale de l'UE est nécessaire pour protéger l'environnement dans leur pays**. Ces résultats sont presque identiques à ceux de la dernière enquête menée en 2019, ce qui souligne la pertinence continue de la politique environnementale de l'UE. Les citoyens sont également préoccupés par les **coûts de la pollution**.

L'enquête illustre également les inquiétudes des citoyens concernant la **pollution et la rareté de l'eau**, leur soutien à **l'économie circulaire** et à la **restauration de la nature**, ainsi que leur sensibilisation aux **incidences des produits chimiques nocifs**.

De plus amples détails sont disponibles en ligne.

(Pour plus d'informations: Adalbert Jahnz – Tél.: + 32 2 295 31 56; Maëlys Dreux – Tél.: +32 2 295 46 73)

Commission establishes AI Office to strengthen EU leadership in safe and trustworthy Artificial Intelligence

Today the Commission has unveiled the Artificial Intelligence (AI) Office, established within the Commission. The AI Office aims at enabling the future development, deployment, and use of AI in a way that fosters societal and economic benefits and innovation, while mitigating risks. The Office will play a **key role in the implementation of the AI Act**, especially in relation to general-purpose AI models. It will also work to **foster research and innovation** in trustworthy AI and position the EU as a leader in international discussions.

Margrethe **Vestager**, Executive Vice-President for a Europe Fit for the Digital Age said: *"The AI-office unveiled today, will help us ensure a coherent implementation of the AI Act. Together with developers and a scientific community, the office will evaluate and test general purpose AI to ensure that AI serves us as humans and uphold our European values."*

Thierry **Breton**, Commissioner for Internal Market, added: *"With the new AI Office and its 140 talented women and men, the Commission will have the necessary expertise to drive the implementation of the AI Act and to reinforce Europe's role as a global standard-setter in AI. The Office will foster a European AI ecosystem that is innovative, competitive and respectful of EU rules and values."*

You will find more information in our press release.

(For more information: Johannes Bahrke – Tel.: +32 2 295 86 15; Thomas Regnier – Tel.: +32 2 299 10 99)

Les candidatures pour le Prix Lorenzo Natali de journalisme sont ouvertes

À partir d'aujourd'hui, les journalistes peuvent poser leur candidature au prix Lorenzo Natali 2024, le prix phare de l'UE pour le journalisme, en présentant des reportages répondant aux critères du prix. Les journalistes qui traitent de questions liées au climat, à l'environnement et à l'énergie, au numérique et aux infrastructures, à l'égalité entre les hommes et les femmes, au développement humain, aux migrations et aux déplacements forcés, à la paix et à la gouvernance, à la croissance et aux emplois durables, ou encore à la jeunesse peuvent poser leur candidature en ligne **jusqu'au 30 juin à minuit**, heure de Bruxelles (HAEC).

La commissaire chargée des partenariats internationaux, Jutta **Urpilainen**, a déclaré: « *Le prix Lorenzo Natali reconnaît et célèbre le rôle essentiel que jouent les journalistes dans la mise en lumière des faits et la manifestation de la vérité. Il encourage les journalistes à faire entendre leur voix, à mettre au jour des récits humains inconnus, et à se défendre en tant que gardiens de la liberté de la presse. Les journalistes peuvent ainsi contribuer aux efforts collectifs visant à construire des sociétés plus empathiques, plus inclusives et plus durables, pour un monde meilleur*. »

Un grand jury composé de journalistes de renommée internationale et de représentants de grandes ONG du monde entier choisira les lauréats dans chaque catégorie. Chaque lauréat remportera 10 000 euros. Le lauréat ou la lauréate de la catégorie du meilleur journaliste émergent se verra également offrir une expérience professionnelle ou un stage auprès d'un partenaire média.

Les lauréats seront proclamés lors de la cérémonie de remise du prix Lorenzo Natali, qui se tiendra à Bruxelles d'ici la fin de l'année.

Le prix rend hommage à l'ancien vice-président de la Commission européenne, Lorenzo Natali, qui a contribué de manière significative à la promotion et l'approfondissement des politiques européennes de développement. Ce prix permet d'entretenir sa mémoire depuis plus trente ans, en distinguant des journalistes dont les reportages incitent au changement. Le prix a été lancé pour la première fois par la Commission européenne en 1992.

De plus amples détails sont disponibles en ligne.

(Pour plus d'informations: Ana Pisonero – Tél.: +32 2 295 43 20; Daniel Puglisi - Tél.: +32 2 296 91 40)

€608.6 million from Horizon Europe to train doctoral candidates under Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions

Today, the Commission announced a new call for Doctoral Networks under the Marie Skłodowska-

Curie Actions (MSCA), part of the EU research and innovation programme Horizon Europe. **€608.6 million in funding** will support consortia of organisations to recruit and train doctoral candidates.

The call is part of the €1.25 billion from Horizon Europe that will support research under MSCA this year, announced in April. It is expected to fund **160 doctoral programmes** spanning multiple scientific fields with a strong focus on interdisciplinary, international and intersectoral cooperation. These doctorates will offer jobs, training, and skills development opportunities to around 2,400 researchers, enabling them to acquire innovation-related competences, and boosting their long-term employability.

Iliana **Ivanova**, Commissioner for Innovation, Research, Culture, Education and Youth, said: *"Through Doctoral Networks under the Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions, Horizon Europe enhances the quality of doctoral education across Europe and worldwide. These innovative networks provide researchers with transferable skills, enriching their career opportunities and boosting their international connections. I encourage organisations from all sectors to apply and build strategic partnerships to attract top research talent that we need in Europe."*

The scheme includes specific incentives to develop **Joint Doctorates**, offering integrated training programmes in synergy with the goals of the blueprint for a European degree. It also offers incentives to develop **Industrial Doctorates** which train researchers and develop their skills outside academia, particularly in industry, businesses and the public sector.

Doctoral Networks are implemented by partnerships of organisations both in academia and beyond, which benefit from the scheme by attracting talent, boosting their global visibility and fostering their international links with other sectors. The deadline for application is 27 November 2024.

More information and guidance on how to apply is available here. Prospective applicants can also attend a dedicated virtual information day on 7 June 2024.

(*For more information: Johanna Bernsel — Tel.: + 32 2 298 66 99; Flore Boutier - Tel.: +32 2 296 60 43)*

Commission clears acquisition of WIGA and WIGA GP by SEFE

The European Commission has approved, under the EU Merger Regulation, the acquisition of sole control of WIGA Transport Beteiligungs-GmbH & Co. KG ('WIGA') and WIGA Verwaltungs-GmbH ('WIGA GP') by SEFE Securing Energy for Europe GmbH ('SEFE'), all of Germany.

The transaction relates primarily to the market for high-pressure gas transmission pipelines in Germany.

The Commission concluded that the notified transaction would not raise competition concerns, given the limited impact on the market structure. The notified transaction was examined under the simplified merger review procedure.

More information is available on the Commission's competition website, in the public case register under the case number M.11520.

(For more information: Lea Zuber – Tel.: +32 2 295 62 98; Sara Simonini - Tel.: +32 2 298 33 67)

Commission clears acquisition of Alight's payroll and professional services business by HIG Capital

The European Commission has approved, under the EU Merger Regulation, the acquisition of sole control of the payroll and professional services business division of Alight, Inc. ('Alight's payroll and professional services business') by H.I.G. Capital, L.L.C. ('HIG Capital'), both of the US.

The transaction relates primarily to human resources services.

The Commission concluded that the notified transaction would not raise competition concerns, given that the companies are not active in the same or vertically related markets. The notified transaction was examined under the simplified merger review procedure.

More information is available on the Commission's competition website, in the public case register under the case number M.11543.

(For more information: Lea Zuber – Tel.: +32 2 295 62 98; Sara Simonini - Tel.: +32 2 298 33 67)

ANNOUNCEMENTS

La Commission accueille la première assemblée générale de l'Alliance industrielle européenne pour les petits réacteurs modulaires

Aujourd'hui et demain, la Commission accueille la première assemblée générale de l'Alliance industrielle européenne pour les petits réacteurs modulaires (PRM), à Bruxelles. Kadri **Simson**, la commissaire en charge de l'énergie, Thierry **Breton**, le commissaire au marché intérieur, et Iliana **Ivanova**, la commissaire à l'innovation, à la recherche, à la culture, à l'éducation et à la jeunesse, participent aujourd'hui à cet évènement, et y prononcent des discours.

Cette manifestation réunira les 277 membres de l'Alliance, originaires des États membres, qui ont présenté leur candidature jusqu'à maintenant ; réunissant l'industrie, les organismes de recherche, les start-ups, les centres de formation, les universités et les organisations de la société civile. Ils discuteront de la marche à suivre pour soutenir des projets concrets, et pour en établir le conseil d'administration et les groupes de travail techniques. Il s'agit de la première réunion officielle de cette Alliance, lancée par la Commission en février.

L'Alliance industrielle pour les PRM vise à accélérer le développement, la démonstration et le déploiement des PRM en Europe d'ici au début des années 2030. Il s'agit de renforcer la chaîne d'approvisionnement nucléaire en Europe en tirant parti de sa capacité de fabrication et d'innovation, tout en renforçant la coopération européenne.

Associés à d'autres sources d'énergie propre, les PRM joueront un rôle dans la réalisation de la transition vers une énergie propre et dans le renforcement de la sécurité énergétique en Europe pour les années à venir en contribuant à décarboner la production d'électricité et l'industrie, à produire de l'hydrogène bas carbone, et à fournir du chauffage aux zones industrielles et urbaines.

(Pour plus d'informations: Tim McPhie – Tél.: +32 2 295 86 02; Johannes Bahrke – Tél.: +32 2 295 86 15; Johanna Bernsel - Tél.: + 32 2 298 66 99)

Commissioner Simson to discuss electricity grids, Russian fossil fuel imports and European Green Deal with EU Energy Ministers

Commissioner for Energy, Kadri **Simson**, will represent the Commission at tomorrow's Energy Council in Brussels. The Commissioner and Ministers will discuss the **development of future-proof electricity grids**, which are key for the integration of renewables in the EU's energy system and the achievement of the clean energy transition.

Two years after its adoption, the Belgian Presidency has invited the Commissioner and Ministers to take stock of progress on the REPowerEU Plan to phase out Russian fossil fuels, and the next steps for its implementation. They will also discuss the **EU's energy preparedness for the next winter** as we progress with gas storage refilling and anticipate further supply chain evolutions at the end of the year.

The Commissioner and Ministers will hold a debate on the **implementation of the European Green Deal** and how it can help make Europe's economy more sustainable. The Commissioner will take the opportunity to remind Member States of the importance and urgency of finalising their **National Energy and Climate Plans** by the end of June, where they should update their policies to reach the EU's 2030 climate and energy goals, based on the Commission's recommendations. In the margins of the Council, the Commissioner will attend the signature of a Memorandum of Understanding between Germany, Italy, and Austria on the development of a hydrogen corridor from North Africa to Central Europe.

At the end of the Council, Commissioner **Simson** will participate in a press conference alongside the Belgian Presidency of the Council, expected at around 18:45 CEST. You will be able to follow it live on EbS+.

(For more information: Tim McPhie – Tel.: +32 2 295 86 02; Giulia Bedini – Tel: +32 2 295 86 61; Ana Crespo Parrondo – Tel.: +32 2 298 13 25)

Commissioner McGuinness visits Athens for discussions on capital markets,

competitiveness and cyber resilience in the finance sector

Commissioner for Financial Services, Financial Stability and Capital Markets Union, Mairead **McGuinness**, will be in Greece from today to Thursday, 30 May. The Commissioner will give a keynote speech on the powerful role of capital markets in transitioning the economy towards more sustainable practices at the 'Climate in the Center of Economy' conference, organised by the Hellenic Capital Market Commission (HCMC).

Over the course of the morning, the Commissioner will also attend meetings with the Chair of Financial Services and Markets Authority (FSMA) Belgium, the Chair of the HCMC and with the Chairman of the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission. In the afternoon, the Commissioner will visit the European Union Agency for Cybersecurity (ENISA) for an exchange on cyber resilience in the finance sector.

On Thursday, the Commissioner will visit the Central Bank of Greece to attend the joint presentation of the European Investment Bank (EIB) survey results 2023 for Greece. During this visit, she will give a keynote speech at the conference 'Transforming the Greek Economy for Competitiveness and Resilience', co-organised by the EIB and the Central Bank of Greece. In the afternoon, the Commissioner will meet with the Governor of the Central Bank of Greece, Ioannis Stournas.

(For more information: Francesca Dalboni – Tel.: +32 229 88170, Marta Perez-Cejuela Romero - Tel.: +32 2 296 37 70)

APPOINTMENTS

The European Commission appoints a new Director for its Directorate-General for Mobility and Transport

Today, the European Commission has decided to appoint **Fotini Ioannidou** to the function of Director for Directorate 'Waterborne' at Directorate-General Mobility and Transport (DG MOVE). This Commission department is responsible for EU policy on mobility and transport. The date of effect will be determined later.

In her new role, Ms Ioannidou, a Greek national, will leverage her extensive professional experience spanning over 30 years in the transport sector, including more than 12 years in management positions at the Commission. She is renowned for her strong leadership and management abilities, as well as her capacity to implement strategic coordination effectively. Her excellent analytical skills and results-oriented approach will enable her to address organisational and operational challenges efficiently. In this new capacity, she will also draw upon her comprehensive knowledge of various transport policy aspects, particularly focusing on logistics, maritime and inland waterway transport, as well as sustainability and innovation in mobility.

Fotini Ioannidou is currently serving as the Acting Director for Directorate ´Waterborne´. She has successfully negotiated several policy files falling under the purview of this Directorate within the context of inter-institutional relations, leading to the conclusion, among others, of four trilogues related to the latest maritime package. Previously, she served as Deputy Director of the same department, being responsible for preparing and coordinating EU positions in the International Maritime Organisation (IMO), including on the issue of shipping decarbonization.

Before joining the Commission in 1994, she worked as project manager for a European research project focused on an integrated network of civil aviation systems.

Ms Ioannidou is an electrical engineer by training and holds two Master's degrees in Electronics and Information Systems.

(For more information: Balazs Ujvari - Tel.: +32 2 295 45 78; Veronica Favalli – Tel.: +32 2 298 72 69)

The European Commission appoints a new Deputy Director General for its Directorate-General for Digital Services

Today, the European Commission has decided to appoint **Philippe Van Damme** to the function of Deputy Director-General responsible for 'Digital Enablers and Innovation' and 'Digital Workplace and

Infrastructure' at the Directorate General for Digital Services (DG DIGIT). This Commission department is responsible for digital services supporting other Commission departments and EU institutions in their daily work. The date of effect will be determined later.

Mr Van Damme possesses over 20 years of experience at the Commission in the digital sector, managing corporate digital workplace and infrastructure services. He has a proven track record in senior management, showcasing strong leadership, innovation, and change management skills. He excels in addressing the challenges introduced by new working methods and has the specialized expertise necessary to navigate large organizations through digital transformation processes.

Philippe Van Damme, a French and Belgian national, is currently Director for 'Digital Workplace and Infrastructure' at DG DIGIT. Prior to that, he served as Head of Unit at DG DIGIT, responsible for Corporate Human Resources Solutions and Information Systems for Human Resources Management. Between 2000 and 2006, he worked at the Directorate-General for Administration where he was the principal architect of the Commission's Human Resource Management system 'Sysper2'. Prior to joining the Commission in 2000, he had various experiences in IT research and engineering within the Belgian Administration. Mr Van Damme has Master's Degrees in Electronic Engineering and in Industrial Management.

(For more information: Balazs Ujvari - Tel.: +32 2 295 45 78; Veronica Favalli – Tel.: +32 2 298 72 69)

The European Commission appoints a new Deputy Director-General for its Directorate-General for Health and Food Safety

Today, the European Commission has decided to appoint **Lorena Boix Alonso** to the function of Deputy Director-General responsible for 'Public Health, Cancer and Health security', 'Digital EU4Health and Health Systems Modernisation', 'Medical Products and Innovation' within the Directorate-General for Health (DG SANTE). This Commission department is responsible for EU policy on food safety and health and for monitoring the implementation of related laws. The date of effect will be determined later.

With two decades of service at the Commission, Ms Boix Alonso has developed extensive expertise in the digital domain, particularly in digital health policies and programmes. She has led key initiatives, such as the the 'European Cancer Imaging initiative, the Genomic infrastructure', the 'Digital Twin of the Human Body' and the EU COVID certificate. Her ability to develop and achieve strategic health policy objectives, combined with her managerial skills, contributed to the successful implementation of the EU e-ID Wallet Regulation. This regulation enables the storage and cross-border use of e-prescriptions, access to e-health records, and the secure provision and sharing of personal health data. Additionally, Ms Boix Alonso has experience in policymaking, legislation, implementation, enforcement, and crisis management in cybersecurity and e-privacy.

Lorena Boix Alonso, a Spanish national, currently serves as the Director for Digital Society, Trust, and Cybersecurity at the Directorate-General for Communications Networks, Content and Technology (DG CNECT). Throughout her career, she has held progressively responsible positions in the Directorate-General for Competition (DG COMP) and DG CNECT. Her experience includes serving as Deputy Head of Cabinet for Digital Agenda and Competition under former Vice President for Competition Neelie Kroes. Ms Boix Alonso joined the Commission in 2003 and is a lawyer by training.

(For more information: Balazs Ujvari - Tel.: +32 2 295 45 78; Veronica Favalli – Tel.: +32 2 298 72 69)

The European Commission appoints the first ever Chief Confidential Counsellor for its staff

The European Commission has decided to appoint **Lene Naesager** to the newly created function of Chief Confidential Counsellor (CCC), an independent function reporting directly to the Commissioner in charge of Administration. The date of effect will be determined later.

With the nomination of this new senior figure, the Commission takes a decisive step in the implementation of the latest Commission decision of December 2023 on the prevention and fight against harassment which was announced in the Commission`s new Human Resources Strategy in 2022. The new anti-harassment framework encourages early reporting of unwanted and inappropriate behaviours and puts the victim at the center of the process. This framework, including the new function of the CCC, is one of the key deliverables of the Strategy.

With a robust professional background spanning 30 years at the Commission, Lene Naesager brings extensive and varied experience within the institution, coupled with a strong management record

that will serve her well in the challenging role of CCC, where she will play a key role in the prevention and fight against harassment. She possesses a wealth of leadership experience, a strategic mindset, and sound political judgment, along with excellent interpersonal skills, empathy and interest in her colleagues' wellbeing. Having held diverse roles across various Commission departments, Naesager has further honed her expertise through significant positions in the Cabinets of two former Commissioners. Notably, she served as Deputy Head of Cabinet for Fischer Boel, former Commissioner for Agriculture and Rural Development, and as a member of Cabinet for Ritt Bjerregaard, former European Commissioner for Environment, Nuclear Safety, and Civil Protection. Her multifaceted experience underscores her adaptability and effectiveness in navigating different managerial roles and policy areas.

Lene Naesager, a Danish national, is currently the Director for Strategy and Corporate Communication at the Directorate-General for Communication (DG COMM). Her previous roles include serving as Acting Director at Directorate-General for Agriculture (DG AGRI). Before joining the Commission in 1994 at the Directorate-General for Competition (DG COMP), she worked as a consultant for the Economic and Social Committee. Ms Naesager holds a PhD in Law.

(For more information: Balazs Ujvari - Tel.: +32 2 295 45 78; Veronica Favalli – Tel.: +32 2 298 72 69)

Liste des points prévus à l'ordre du jour des prochaines réunions de la Commission

Veuillez noter que ces informations sont données sous réserve de modifications.

Prochains événements de la Commission européenne

Eurostat: communiqués de presse

MEX/24/2986